By arrangement with the Colonial Society of Massachusetts
the Editors of the New England Quarterly
are pleased to publish the winning essay
of the 2018
Walter Muir Whitehill Prize in Early American History

City on the Other Hill: The Plough Patent, the Company of Husbandmen, and a Radical Puritan Colonization Project

DAVID R. COMO

THE ill-starred "Company of Husbandmen" deserves special mention among the many quixotic, failed colonization schemes of the seventeenth century. Organized in 1630 to exploit a patent granted by Sir Ferdinando Gorges and his Council of New England, this joint-stock venture sought to create a colony around the river "Sagadahoc" in what today is southern Maine. Despite considerable efforts, the enterprise failed, and by 1633 the project was effectively abandoned amidst indebtedness and internal backbiting. Nevertheless, as recent scholarship demonstrates, failed colonial ventures often provide surprising insights, helping to clarify the contexts that generated such schemes and casting into relief the conditions and

I am very grateful to Michael Winship, who suffered through earlier drafts of this piece, offering suggestions that greatly improved the final version. Bob Anderson and an anonymous reader also furnished helpful feedback. Peter Lake provided inspired advice while trapped on a coach between Oxford and London.

The New England Quarterly, vol. XCII, no. 3 (September 2019). © 2019 by The New England Quarterly. All rights reserved. https://doi.org/10.1162/tneq_a_00757.

forces that ultimately strangled projects before they came to fruition.[1] The case of the "Husbandmen" beckons with particular allure, in large part because of the tantalizing first glimpse of the project, which sailed into the pages of John Winthrop's journal in 1631.

In his entry for July 6 of that year, Winthrop recorded that "A small Shippe of 60: tu. arived at Natascott, mr. Graves master: she brought 10 passingers from London, they came with a Patent to Sagadahocke, but not liking the place, they came hether. their Shippe drewe 10: foote, & went up to waterton, but she rane on gronde twice by the waye: these were the Company called the husbandmen & their shippe called the ploughe." After a brief interlude in port, the *Plough* and its passengers sailed away, seeking to salvage their venture in the Caribbean, but they were again frustrated. As Winthrop reported on August 19, "The Ploughe returned to Ch[arle]s towne, after she had beene on her waye to the Chr[ist]o[f]er Ilandes about 3: weekes: was so leeke she could not return there." Bereft of a seaworthy vessel, the so-called "Husbandmen" were temporarily stranded in Massachusetts. The sojourn of the *Plough*'s passengers in the Bay was brief and unhappy. In a later interpolation, Winthrop commented that "most of them proved famylistes, & vanished away."[2] This was of course a reference to the furtive and infamous sect, the Family of Love, alleged followers of the Messianic sixteenth-century prophet Hendrik Niclaes.[3]

Scholars have long been intrigued by Winthrop's cryptic comment. Nevertheless, our knowledge of the "Company of

[1] Karen Ordahl Kupperman, *Providence Island, 1630–1641* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1993); Alison Games, *The Web of Empire: English Cosmopolitans in the Age of Expansion, 1560–1660* (Oxford, UK: Oxford University Press, 2008), 181–218; Ignacio Gallup-Diaz, *The Door of the Seas and the Key of the Universe: Indian Politics and Imperial Rivalry in the Darién, 1640–1750,* rev. ed. (New York: Columbia University Press, 2005); for a colony less "failed" than abandoned, see Justin Roberts, "Surrendering Surinam: The Barbadian Diaspora and the Expansion of the English Sugar Frontier, 1650–75," *William and Mary Quarterly* 3rd ser., 73 (2016): 225–56.

[2] *The Journal of John Winthrop, 1630–1649,* ed. Richard S. Dunn et al. (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996), 53–54, 56 (hereafter *Winthrop's Journal*).

[3] On Familism, see Alastair Hamilton, *The Family of Love* (Cambridge, UK: James Clarke, 1981); Christopher Marsh, *The Family of Love in English Society, 1550–1630* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1994).

Husbandmen," or the "Plough Company" as the consortium is sometimes known, has remained largely static since the nineteenth century when Winthrop's papers were first published. Several letters relating to the project were printed by the Massachusetts Historical Society (including two from the company leadership in London), shedding light on the enterprise.[4] Subsidiary evidence emerged about the patent and investors, and by 1903 scholars and antiquaries had assembled the essential surviving documents relating to the Husbandmen and their "Plough Patent."[5] While scant new evidence emerged thereafter, Winthrop's teasing reference to the "famylistes" aboard the *Plough* continued to excite occasional interest. Philip Gura, for instance, opened his classic study of New England religious dissent with Winthrop's account of the ship's arrival. Nevertheless, neither Gura nor other modern commentators have added substantively to Winthrop's enigmatic verdict.[6]

[4]"The Winthrop Papers," *Collections of the Massachusetts Historical Society,* 4th ser., 7 (Boston: Massachusetts Historical Society, 1865), 88–105; they were republished in *The Winthrop Papers,* ed. Allyn B. Forbes, 6 vols. (Boston: Massachusetts Historical Society, 1929–), 3:67–71, 101–3, 122–24; 4:447–49 (cited hereafter as *Winthrop Papers*); the texts are now readily accessible in *The Winthrop Papers Digital Edition*. The present article cites the two letters of the Company of Husbandmen from the manuscript originals: Ms N-1097, John Davis Papers, Massachusetts Historical Society, Boston, MA (hereafter MHS). The first letter, Company of Husbandmen to their members in Massachusetts, March 8, 1632 (cited hereafter as *Husbandmen 1*); the second letter, from Company of Husbandmen to John Winthrop, December 1, 1632 [cited hereafter as "*Husbandmen 2*"].

[5]Charles Edward Banks, *Colonel Alexander Rigby: A Sketch of His Career and Connection with Maine as Proprietor of the Plough Patent and President of the Province of Lygonia* (Portland, ME: Privately Printed, 1885); James Phinney Baxter, *George Cleeve of Casco Bay, 1630–1667, with Collateral Documents* (Portland, ME: The Gorges Society, 1885); *Documentary History of the State of Maine: Vol. VII Containing The Farnham Papers, 1603–1688,* ed. Mary Frances Farnham, *Collections of the Maine Historical Society,* 2nd ser. (Portland, ME: The Thurston Print, 1901), 133–36; Victor Channing Sanborn, "Stephen Bachiler and the Plough Company of 1630," *The Genealogist* N.S., 19 (1903): 270–84. The later history of Lygonia province is much illuminated in Hannah Farber, "The Rise and Fall of the Province of Lygonia, 1643–1658," *New England Quarterly* 82 (2009): 490–513.

[6]Philip Gura, *A Glimpse of Sion's Glory: Puritan Radicalism in New England* (Middletown, CT: Wesleyan University Press, 1984), 3–4; for other brief discussions of the venture, see Stephen Foster, "New England and the Challenge of Heresy, 1630 to 1660: the Puritan Crisis in Transatlantic Perspective," *WMQ,* 3rd. ser., 38 (1981): 641; Faren Siminoff, *Crossing the Sound: The Rise of Atlantic American Communities in Seventeenth-Century Eastern Long Island* (New York: NYU Press, 2004), 98–101.

This study offers a new perspective on the Plough Patent and the Company of Husbandmen. Building on recent work undertaken on the radical Puritan milieu of early Stuart England, the essay mobilizes newly unearthed manuscript sources to reinterpret the enterprise. Through detailed reconstruction of the company membership, it will be argued that the Plough project was likely spearheaded, at least in part, by heterodox Puritans seeking to carve out a colony in the New World as a refuge from recent and distressing assaults on their position in London. I will suggest that the *Plough*'s purported human cargo of "famylistes" was not a mere figment of Winthrop's imagination, and that some of those involved in the company were closely tied to sectarian networks in London. The Plough project, then, appears to have constituted a godly colonization scheme of very different temper from that of Massachusetts Bay, and its history suggests that well before the founding of Roger Williams's Providence, dissident elements within the English godly community imagined the creation of a plantation that would serve as a haven for people alienated not just by the increasing sacramentalism and Arminianism of Laud's Church of England, but also by aspects of mainstream Puritan divinity and practice. This vision was not, however, shared uniformly by all involved in the Plough project. By carefully chronicling the history of the enterprise, this article demonstrates that the Plough venture was from its inception undermined by internal divisions, exacerbating the already formidable fiscal and logistical obstacles facing the company. Nevertheless, despite internal squabbles, repeated efforts were made to use the Plough patent as the basis for a new colony, and this article shows that the Husbandmen labored to revive their design into the 1640s. The collapse of this ambitious alternative Puritan colonization scheme, while interesting in its own right, also points towards lessons about the early history of the Massachusetts Bay Colony, helping to make sense of the response later in the 1630s to the threat of "antinomianism" borne by Wheelwright, Hutchinson, and their backers, and furthering our understanding of the comparative strength and durability of the Bay Colony in its embryonic phase.

The Plough Patent

The Plough Patent itself does not survive. The most extensive description of the charter derives from a much later abstract that claimed Sir Ferdinando Gorges and the Earl of Warwick, on behalf of the Council of New England on June 26, 1630 granted to "Bryan Bincks, John Dye, John Smith & others their Associates" a tract of land in what is today southern Maine. As was common in early land grants of the crown and companies, the geographic scope of the patent was hazy, referring to ill-defined, if not fictional, place names and landmarks: the abstract claimed that the charter granted the patentees "Two Islands in the River Sagedahock, near the South Side thereof about 60 miles from the Sea & also all the Tract containing 40 miles in Length & 40 miles in breadth upon the South side of the River Sagedahock," inclusive of all bays, rivers, ports and creeks within that area.[7] The grant's imprecision soon generated controversy, but later accounts suggest the patent was probably intended to refer to a large expanse of land south and west of the mouth of the today's Kennebec River, running along the Atlantic coast towards the modern city of Portland.[8] According to the abstract, the region was to be styled "the Province of Ligonia."

The patent was one of a flurry of charters issued by Gorges's Council beginning in 1628, inaugurated by the issuance of the first grant to the Company of New England (soon to be

[7]*Farnham Papers,* 133–36; for a similar, largely congruent abstract, of earlier date, see CO 1/33/109, fol. 287r–v, The National Archives of the United Kingdom (hereafter "TNA").

[8]Uncertainty revolved around whether the grant ran along the coastline or began sixty miles upriver, which would have landlocked the tract in Maine's interior (uncertainties made worse because the two islands named in the patent were "doubtfull"). For the disputed interpretations of the patent's bounds, see *Husbandmen 1*; *Winthrop Papers,* 5:75–76; *Winthrop's Journal,* 704–5; William D. Williamson, *The History of the State of Maine; From Its First Discovery, A. D. 1602, to the Separation, A. D. 1820,* 2 vols. (Hallowell, ME: Glazier, Masters & Smith, 1839), 1:301–2; "October Meeting, 1884," *Proceedings of the Massachusetts Historical Society,* new ser., 1 (1884): 231–32 (hereafter *MHS Proceedings*). For various hypothetical maps of the grant, see John Reid, *Maine, Charles II and Massachusetts: Governmental Relationships in Early Northern New England* (Portland: Maine Historical Society, 1977), 251; Farber, "Lygonia," 500.

rechristened as the Massachusetts Bay Company).[9] The Plough Patent, encompassing some 1600 square miles, represented a significant concession, particularly as it allegedly conferred on the patentees "power to make Laws &c." In contrast to many early land grants conferred by Gorges's Council of New England, this patent authorized its recipients to erect a government under their own control.

Later descriptions of the patent also help identify those actually nominated in the charter. The abstract named "Bryan Bincks, John Dye, John Smith & others their Associates" as initial grantees while also suggesting "John Dye & John Smith, Tho: [J]upe & other Survivors of Bryan *Bincks & others*" sold the patent in 1643. Another description of the charter from the 1670s added the names "*Grace Harding,* and *John Roach* of *London*" to Dye and Jupe as original patentees.[10] These were likely the only men nominated in the document since in 1646 Winthrop recorded that the original charter named "6: or 8: patentees."[11]

These individuals formed the nucleus of the new joint-stock company that coalesced to pursue the colonization project. The six or eight men named in the patent were reinforced by additional investors who became full-fledged company members. These additional members included Roger and Samuel Binckes (brothers of Bryan), Nathaniel Whetham, Henry Fowkes, John Robinson, Brian Kipling, Peter Johnson, and John Cerman. The syndicate acquired a small ship, the *Plough*.[12] Several members agreed to travel personally to New England,

[9]For the now missing Massachusetts grant, see Robert E. Moody, "A Re-Examination of the Antecedents of the Massachusetts Bay Company's Charter of 1629," *MHS Proceedings,* 3rd ser., 69 (1947–1950): 56–80. Prominent Council charters in this period included the Plymouth and "Muscongus" Patents (see *MHS Proceedings,* new ser. 2 [1835–1855]: 544–45); for other contemporaneous grants, see *Farnham Papers,* 95–179; "Records of the Council for New England," *Proceedings of the American Antiquarian Society* (1867): 49–58.

[10]William Hubbard, *A Narrative of the Troubles with the Indians in New-England* (Boston, 1677), appendix, "A Narrative of the Troubles with the Indians in New-England," 9.

[11]*Winthrop's Journal,* 619.

[12]In listing the Company's goods, the Husbandmen remarked that "there is alsoe the ould shipp," suggesting the vessel was purchased. *Husbandmen* 2.

including two of the enumerated core patentees, Bryan Binckes and John Smith. At least three other company members sailed on the *Plough* in 1631, John Crispe, Peter Johnson, and John Cerman. Meanwhile, the core patentees John Dye, Grace Hardwin, Thomas Jupe, and John Roch remained home during the first wave of colonization, managing the enterprise from England and committing goods to be shipped on the *Plough*. There was no hard boundary between company governors in England and settlers dispatched to America; from the beginning, the lines were blurred, with full-fledged company members traveling to New England, and others staying in London to oversee the enterprise. Within a year, the company had likely recruited a suitably puritanical pastor to lead the emigré flock. In 1631, the *Plough* departed London, with its ten passengers and its stock of goods.

The society also acquired its name, the Company of Husbandmen. The origin of this appellation is unclear, but it was certainly a moniker that the adventurers applied to themselves.[13] As we will see, all the core members of the company were London artisans or tradesmen (not husbandmen or farmers) suggesting the title was selected for its metaphorical resonance; the image of honest husbandry, particularly in the context of a supposedly wild, uncultivated land, hinted at a potent colonizing impulse—imagery that may also have been linked to the name of the company's ship, the *Plough*. The noun husbandman also had evocative scriptural echoes—in the words of the Apostle James, "Be patient therefore, brethren, unto the coming of the Lord. Behold, the husbandman waiteth for the precious fruit of the earth, and hath long patience for it." The extant correspondence of the company is steeped in spiritual language and allusion. The London patentees' first surviving letter to the Plough settlers began with a grandiloquent Pauline flourish, "Grace and pese be mullteplyd for eure," before addressing the "Cristen Bretheren" in New England as "members of the sam bode . . . in the name of our lord and Safiour Jesus

[13]*Husbandmen* 2 was signed "for ourselves and the rest of the Companie of Husbandmen."

Crist," hinting that from the outset, the company was imagined not merely as a legal entity but as a religious fellowship. The entire enterprise was unquestionably conceived in an environment of intense, even extreme, godly enthusiasm.

London's Antinomian Controversy and the Ministry of Peter Shaw

Certainly, the broadest context for the Company of Husbandmen and the Plough Patent was the increasingly distempered state of the English church. After the pyrotechnics of the Parliament of 1628–29, Charles I had turned increasingly towards Bishop William Laud and other hardline, sacramentalist divines to crack down on nonconformists and impose a ceremonialist vision on the church. Like the Massachusetts Bay Company, the Plough venture surely emerged out of the growing despair felt by godly Protestants over this increasingly unappetizing religious order.

Winthrop's cryptic dismissal of the *Plough* passengers as "famylistes" hints at a second, more specific religious context. For even as Puritans began to feel the weight of Laudian repression, they were simultaneously experiencing their own internal theological battles, involving mudslinging and accusations of "Familism" and "antinomianism." Recent research has greatly enhanced our knowledge of the controversies that reverberated through London beginning in the 1620s. A series of provocative preachers, including John Traske, John Eaton, and Robert Towne, disrupted London's Puritan community beginning around 1628, creating intense debate over doctrines at the heart of mainstream Puritan practical divinity. These clerics challenged the dominant pietistic regime championed by godly ministers with its intense focus on the performance of holy duties and ordinances and its ceaseless cycle of spiritual discipline. The upstart preachers contended that these reigning forms of Puritan piety amounted to a new species of works righteousness, which denigrated the power of God's free grace. Downplaying works of the moral law and reliance on outward signs of sanctification, these preachers typically emphasized that

everything necessary for salvation had already been accomplished for believers and that the spiritual mortifications of the godly entrapped them in a form of pharisaical legalism. While they often portrayed themselves as mere Protestant purists—seeking to revive the doctrines of free grace and justification by faith alone—such ministers and their disciples often pushed towards positions unacceptable within the reformed tradition. Thus, so-called antinomians frequently insisted that true believers were free from the moral law and indeed that they were in some sense free from sin, at least in God's sight.[14]

Such positions were perceived as dangerously heterodox by more traditional godly clerics who came to denounce their opponents as antinomians, libertines, or even Familists. This last accusation was often quite unjust: there is little sign that most so-called antinomians had any truck with the exotic teachings of the followers of Hendrik Niclaes (alias H. N.), whose tendency to allegorize the bible, to engage in doctrinaire nicodemism, and to portray believers as unified with Christ or God had been ruthlessly suppressed in Elizabethan England. Nevertheless, there were enough similarities in doctrine to make the charge plausible; moreover, a handful of the most extreme antinomians did indeed dabble with the teachings of H. N. and other reformation mystics and prophets, which were kept alive by a small handful of secretive, genuine self-identifying Familists.[15]

Beginning in 1628, fierce debates among the godly erupted publicly, and several accused antinomians appeared before the church courts. Among the most controversial was Peter Shaw, a young Cambridge-trained divine who, despite a distinguished

[14]Foster, "Challenge of Heresy," 624–60; David R. Como, *Blown by the Spirit: Puritanism and the Emergence of an Antinomian Underground in Pre–Civil-War England* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2004); Stephen Hampton, "Richard Holdsworth and the Antinomian Controversy," *Journal of Theological Studies* N.S., 62 (2011): 218–50; for these conflicts, with particular reference to New England, see Theodore Dwight Bozeman, *The Precisianist Strain: Disciplinary Religion and the Antinomian Backlash in Puritanism to 1638* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2004).

[15]For Familism in early Stuart England, see Como, *Blown by the Spirit,* 38–49, 469–73 and "The Family of Love and the Making of English Revolutionary Religion: The Confessions and 'Conversions' of Giles Creech," *Journal of Medieval and Early Modern Studies* 48 (2018): 553–98.

godly pedigree, had developed eccentric, inflammatory opinions. Shaw was first a curate in Lancashire where his doctrine drew the ire of local ministers.[16] Shaw soon migrated to London, earning a devoted following preaching from multiple city pulpits, including St. Magnus and St. Laurence Old Jewry. By early 1629, he had secured a regular Wednesday evening lecture at 5 PM in the parish of St. Michael Crooked Lane where avid disciples flocked to his sermons. It was claimed that "he hath begot such a faction, that if he preach not, his followers, have refused upon the Sondayes to hear either sermon's, or divine prayer, but rest at home."[17]

The appearance of this charismatic preacher, with a gaggle of devotees, alarmed local ministers. This is no doubt because Shaw's acolytes combined their attachment to him with an equally vehement rejection of other clergymen: "His followers vilifie and defame all other Ministers, clamouring, that because Mr Shaw cutt's of the roote of the Arminians, ergo it is that all the Ministers of the cite oppose him, for they are all tainted with Arminianisme." This undifferentiated hostility to the whole London clerical fraternity galvanized an impressive and unlikely roster of divines—Puritan, Laudian, and Calvinist conformist alike—who mobilized against Shaw, resulting in a High Commission trial, which dragged out through 1629–30. The case generated a dossier of evidence, outlining Shaw's supposed errors and heresies. The charges against him, which have been analyzed in detail elsewhere, placed him squarely in line with other accused antinomians of the period. He allegedly declared that "A belever is free from the Law; the morall Law," that "Sanctification and holines . . . is no part of the forme of a Christian," and that "for a Christian to comfort himselfe, because god hath enabled him to reforme his wayes and to walke upwrightly towards god and man, is to deny Christ and

[16]David R. Como and Peter Lake, "Puritans, Antinomians and Laudians in Caroline London: The Strange Case of Peter Shaw and its Contexts," *Journal of Ecclesiastical History* 50 (1999): 684–715; Como, *Blown by the Spirit*, 66–67, 317–18, 334–48; R. Cunliffe Shaw, *The Records of a Lancashire Family* (Preston, UK: The Guardian Press, 1940), esp. 128–33.

[17]Como and Lake, "Puritans, Antinomians and Laudians," 708–12.

to be entangled in the law." However, several witnesses deposed that Shaw strayed into even more unacceptable territory, flirting with classically "Familist" opinions: thus, he supposedly preached that "a belever hath the same holynes with Christ and that not imputed holiness only, but inherent." Indeed, Shaw reportedly delivered that "a Christian is so Christed with Christ, and godded with god, that he is as Christ before god," thus repeating perhaps the most infamous slogan of the Family of Love. Shaw was also accused of another notoriously "Familistical" conceit, "that the soule of man is mortall."[18]

While it is difficult to assess these hostile charges, the allegations reveal how Shaw's myriad detractors perceived his message. All saw him as an arch-antinomian, and in later years, he was routinely lumped together with other notorious purveyors of the same errors, such as Traske, Eaton, and Towne.[19] More intractable still is the question of whether Shaw was, as his accusers insinuated, a rank Familist. The charges against him echoed longstanding stereotypes of Familist heterodoxy, and it is possible that his critics forcibly molded his words to pre-existing canons of error; however, in 1638 the cutler Giles Creech, who indisputably had consorted with London's surviving underground Familists, provided the authorities with intelligence on a group known as the "Familists of the Valley" and claimed that "Mr Shaw and after Mr. Gray a young minister were great on this way." One well-informed insider, then, believed that Shaw was indeed influenced by genuine Familism.[20]

By 1638, however, Shaw had abandoned London. Owing to gaps in the High Commission records, the precise chronology of his case is uncertain. But at some stage in late 1630, he was censured for his heterodoxy.[21] The slippery Shaw now

[18]Como and Lake, "Puritans, Antinomians and Laudians," 707, 709, 711–12.

[19]John Sedgwick, *Antinomianisme Anatomized. Or, a A Glasse for the Lawlesse* (1643), 1; *Reports of Cases in the Courts of Star Chamber and High Commission,* ed. S. R. Gardiner, *Camden Society, N.S.*, 39 (1886): 185.

[20]Como, "Giles Creech," 594; John Etherington, who also flirted with Familism in his youth, likewise named Shaw among those "that have taught the doctrine of H. N." in London. John Etherington, *A Brief Discovery of the Blasphemous Doctrine of Familisme* (London, 1645), 45.

[21]Como, *Blown by the Spirit,* 335.

apparently reconciled with the authorities. Presumably using his Lancashire connections, he obtained a chaplaincy, then a fellowship, in the Collegiate Church of Manchester, and by 1634, he was back in the North. His rapprochement with the establishment was completed in 1638 when Shaw was presented to his father's old rectory of Radcliffe in Lancashire, a position he held into the Civil War.

The London Wing of the Company of Husbandmen

At this point, the story of the Company of Husbandmen collides with the tale of the rise, fall, and rehabilitation of Peter Shaw. When Shaw was preferred to the rectory of Radcliffe, he entered composition to pay First Fruits and Tenths to the crown. Standing as one of his sureties was "Joh[ann]es Dye p[ar]ochie s[an]cti Andree Hubbard Lond[on] Skinner."[22] This was without question the same John Dye who served as the nucleus of the Company of Husbandmen. Dye was named in the original patent, he signed both surviving letters from the company, and in one of the those letters, the Husbandmen requested that proceeds from their goods remaining in New England were to be remitted to "John Dye dwellinge in Fillpott Lane or unto John Roach, Grace Hardinge, or Thomas Juppe dwellinge in Crooked Lane." This dissolves all doubt about the identity of Shaw's surety and the Plough patentee, for independent records demonstrate that John Dye, the skinner of St. Andrew Hubbard, lived in Philpot Lane.[23] All evidence suggests that the skinner Dye was a driving force, if not the central organizer, behind the Plough Patent.

The pivotal figure in the Company of Husbandmen was thus also, demonstrably, an associate and supporter of the accused "Familist" Peter Shaw. This in itself is enough to raise serious suspicions about the project. But to this must be added the fact that most of the other core members of the company

[22] E 334/19, fol. 227r, TNA.

[23] *Husbandman* 2. The Skinners' Company 1641 poll tax return recorded John Dye's residence as "Philpott Lane," confirming that Shaw's surety and the Husbandman were the same man. E 179/251/22, item 31, fol. 217r, TNA.

were inhabitants of the small parish of St. Michael Crooked Lane, the epicenter of Shaw's brief but spectacular ministry. Unlike the wealthy merchants and gentlemen named in the Massachusetts Bay Company charter, the Plough patentees of St. Michael were humble, even plebeian, in origin. John Roch, although a member of the Fishmongers' Company, was a "brushmaker" by occupation; intriguingly, his house was "at the Plough" on the west side of St. Michael's Lane.[24] Grace Hardwin, a working candle-maker who lived immediately next to Roch at "Cowe's Face," was free of the Waxchandlers' guild.[25] A few doors away lived Thomas Jupe, a member of the Girdlers' Company.[26] Three of the original patentees were thus near neighbors, dwelling within meters of one another. John Crispe, living on the north side of Crooked Lane in 1638, was a "plaisterer."[27] Another Husbandman of the parish before his death in 1637 was Henry Fowkes, a plateworker, that is, an artisan who fashioned objects from metal.[28] Similarly, John Smith, who was nominated in the patent and who eventually sailed on the *Plough,* was likely the plateworker of this name who lived in St. Michael in the 1620s.[29] These were not major

[24]*The Inhabitants of London in 1638,* ed. T. C. Dale, 2 vols. (London: Society of Genealogists, 1931), 1:147; Burials, July 11, 1632; June 22, 1636; December 23, 1637, P69/MIC3/A/001/MS11367, London Metropolitan Archives (hereafter cited as "LMA"). His occupation is confirmed in the Fishmongers' 1641 poll tax returns, which list him as "Brushmaker" of St. Michael Crooked Lane. E 179/251/22, item 27, fol. 4r, TNA; St. Michael's Lane was often known as Crooked Lane, explaining why Hardwin, Roch, and Jupe are described as "dwellinge in Crooked Lane" in the letter of December 1632, but of St. Michael's Lane in the tithe survey: see, *The Norweb Collection: Tokens of the British Isles, 1575–1750, Part VII, City of London,* ed. R. H. Thompson and M. J. Dickinson, *Sylloge of Coins of the British Isles* (London: Spink and Son, 2007), 59: plate 50, no. 7617.

[25]*Inhabitants of London,* 1:147; Baptisms: Jan. 17, 1630, P69/MIC3/A/001/MS11367 and P69/MIC3/B/009/MS01188/001, 159, LMA.

[26]*Inhabitants of London,* 1:147; E 179/251/22 (Girdlers), fol. 87, TNA.

[27]*Inhabitants of London,* 1:149; Crispe resided in St. Michael in November 1633, when he married Alice Lettice at St. Mary Magdalene Old Fish Street: P69/MRY10/A/001/MS11529, fol. 75v, LMA; he was described as "John Cripse plaisterer" when he and Alice baptized a child in 1638 and as "John Crispe" in 1642: Baptisms: Feb. 4, 1637/8, Feb. 20, 1641/2, P69/MIC3/A/001/MS11367, LMA.

[28]Burials: Jan. 26, 1636/7, P69/MIC3/A/001/MS11367, LMA.

[29]The common name complicates identification, but *Husbandmen 1* claimed John Smith of the *Plough* was married to Ann and had a minor daughter (both sailing on

international merchants: in the main, the Husbandmen were moderately prosperous artisans, many of them apparently manufacturers. While not rich, these men were respectable householders, the "middling" citizens who furnished the backbone of neighborhood and company governance in London; indeed, notwithstanding the possibility that they may have harbored esoteric religious interests, several served as parochial or guild officers in later years.[30]

The core membership of the Company of Husbandmen included one of the few known lay backers of Peter Shaw and a series of citizens from the parish where Shaw exercised his charismatic homiletic gifts. It is highly unlikely that this was a coincidence: Shaw's ministry—and its wider significance as a high point in London's antinomian controversies of 1628–31—provides the plausible context for Winthrop's comment on the *Plough* passengers that "most of them proved famylistes, & vanished away." At least one and probably several of the organizers of the project were likely admirers of the embattled minister. It seems reasonable to conclude the same about the Husbandmen aboard the *Plough,* at least two of whom (Crispe and Smith) were probably residents of St. Michael. Moreover, the timing of the grant—June 1630—coincided exactly with the explosive High Commission case against Shaw, which was probably initiated in early 1629 and led to his sentencing in late 1630.

Further clues to the religious ambience of the company can be detected among those Husbandmen who lived beyond

---

the *Whale* in 1632). There were two John Smiths in St. Michael in the 1620s. One, a plateworker, was married to "Anna," and apparently had a single child, Susanna, who survived infancy and would have been eleven in 1632. This family disappears from parish records after 1631, and only the other John Smith (a boxmaker, d. 1647, married to Priscilla in 1631–33) resided in St. Michael in 1638. See Baptisms: September 17, 1620; March 25, 1621; January 13, 1622; February 23, 1624; March 28,1624; July 22, 1627; December 14, 1628; Burials: January 16, 1622; January 31, 1625; June 14, 1630; January 22, 1648, P69/MIC3/A/001/MS11367, LMA; *Inhabitants of London,* 1:147–49.

[30] *Inhabitants of London,* 147–49, for their middling status in the 1638 tithe survey; John Roch was churchwarden (1639–41), Thomas Jupe was auditor of churchwardens' accounts (1644), and Grace Hardwin was churchwarden (1646). P69/MIC3/B/009/MS01188/001, 245, 253–54, 278, 293, LMA. Hardwin was master of the Waxchandlers in 1651: *London Citizens in 1651,* ed. J. C. Whitebrook (London: Hutchings and Romer, 1910), 5.

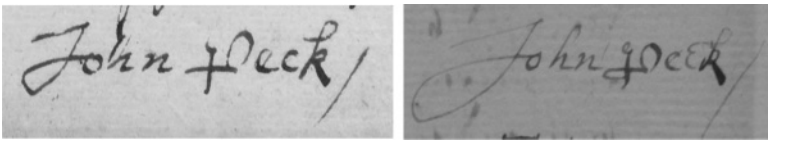
Crooked Lane. Bryan Binckes, Roger Binckes, and Samuel Binckes, siblings, were apparently from a similar artisanal social stratum: Roger, a tailor, in 1631 inhabited St. Ann Blackfriars;[31] Samuel Binckes, too, apparently lived in or near London.[32] A fourth brother, Henry Binckes, also a tailor, resided in the parish of St. Sepulchre at his death in 1625. Henry's nuncupative will, delivered during his final illness in January 1625, may offer another tantalizing hint regarding the spiritual temper of the company. Henry was clearly close to his brothers: he named Roger and Samuel as executors and bequeathed to "Roger Binckes his brother five pounds of lawfull money" and to "Samuell and Bryant Bincks his brothers Tenne pounds a peice." Attending Henry on his deathbed and recording the dying tailor's wishes was John Peck, who eventually signed Henry's nuncupative will. This was almost certainly the same John Peck who in 1616 confessed to being a chief supporter of the notorious John Traske, perhaps the most colorfully unhinged religious leader of the era. Traske is most renowned for his phase in the 1610s as a "Judaizer" when he resurrected the Saturday Sabbath and other Old Testament ceremonies. But in the 1620s, Traske became one of London's most infamous antinomian preachers.[33] Comparison of Peck's signature, attached to his confession, against one eight years later on Henry Binckes's will strongly suggests that we are dealing with the same John Peck.[34] Thus, an intimate associate of John Traske, one of the

[31]Roger and his wife Elizabeth buried several children at St. Ann's, 1631–33: Burials: January 7, 1631; July 5, 1632; July 6, 1633, P69/ANN/A/008/MS04510/001, LMA. In October 1631, he described himself as tailor of St. Ann Blackfriars: DL/A/D/002/MS10091/013, fol. 203v, LMA. He was again called a tailor of St. Ann Blackfriars when apprenticing his son to a draper in 1637: *Records of London's Livery Companies Online*: http://www.londonroll.org/event/?company=drp&event_id=DREB3208, accessed on August 2, 2018.

[32]Samuel signed one letter of the Company of Husbandmen, revealing his presence in London in December 1632; he was perhaps the Samuel Binckes, residing in St. Giles in the Fields in Feb. 1639: P82/GIS/A/04/001, fol. 19v, LMA.

[33]Como, *Blown by the Spirit,* 138–75, 348–61, 457–68.

[34]Advocates MS. 33.1.6, vol. 20, fol. 60r, National Library of Scotland, Edinburgh; PROB 11/145/334, TNA. "Henry Binckes," PROB 10/419, TNA, is the signed nuncupative will. See Como, *Blown by the Spirit,* 173–74; *Register of Admissions to the Honourable Society of the Middle Temple,* ed. H. A. C. Sturgess (London: Butterworth, 1949), 102. Peck was heir of John Peck of Bockerell, Devon, gent.



(Left) Confession of John Peck. Advocates MS. 33.1.6, vol. 20, fol. 60r (by permission of the National Library of Scotland). (Right) John Peck signature on Henry Binckes's will, PROB 10/419 (by permisson of TNA).

most infamous antinomian preachers of the day, was at the deathbed of a man whose three brothers anchored the Company of Husbandmen. Perhaps significantly, in the late 1620s, Henry's brother and executor Roger Binckes, the Husbandman, also lived in Traske's home parish of St. Bride Fleet Street, where Traske preached to the prisoners of the Fleet.[35] Again, all of this might merely amount to an improbable coincidence (relating chiefly, it must be said, not to the Husbandmen, but to their deceased sibling). At the very least, however, the evidence appears to place the Binckes brothers in the same radius of enthusiastic, extreme godly piety occupied by Shaw, Dye, and the Crooked Lane Husbandmen.

While the Binckes brothers constituted a secondary center of gravity for the London wing of the project, other members of the Company of Husbandmen likewise lived in or around the city. Nathaniel Whetham was a young west-end white baker, while Brian Kipling was a shipwright from Southwark.[36] "Petter Wouster," who ventured ten pounds and sponsored the emigration of Nathaniel Merriman in 1632, was almost certainly Peter Worcester, merchant tailor of St. Edmund the King parish.[37]

[35]In 1621 Traske and his wife Dorothy baptized a child at St. Bride's; on May 8, 1626, a son of "Mr. John Traske" was buried there; Roger and Elizabeth Binckes baptized a child in July 1627. P69/BRI/A/004/MS06538, fol. 129r, LMA; Baptisms: October 3, 1621 and July 11, 1627, P69/BRI/A/001/MS06536, LMA; for Traske's post in the Fleet, see C 8/58/59, TNA.

[36]For Whetham, see William Cecil Dampier Whetham, *A History of the Life of Colonel Nathaniel Whetham: A Forgotten Soldier of the Civil Wars* (London: Longmans, Green and Co., 1907); for Kipling, see P71/OLA/009, fols. 191v, 247v, LMA; C 2/JasI/S39/29, TNA; SP 16/321/67, fol. 137r, TNA, showing a signature closely matching that on *Husbandmen* 2.

[37]Sarah Alice Worcester, *The Descendants of Rev. William Worcester* (Boston: E.F. Worcester, 1914), xi. Parish surveys called him "Peter Woster" in 1638 and 1642. *Inhabitants of London,* 1:53; SP 28/193, part 5, fol. 161r, TNA.

John Robinson was possibly a young parishioner of St. Margaret New Fish Street.[38] The picture that emerges, then, suggests that the core of the Plough project centered on St. Michael Crooked Lane, which was home to at least five, and perhaps six, of the Husbandmen. John Dye, a leader of the whole enterprise, lived a few moments' walk east, in St. Andrew Hubbard.

Despite suggestive hints linking the project to Peter Shaw (and, less certainly, to John Traske), we should not assume that we are dealing with some sort of underground Familist cell, waiting to transport itself across the Atlantic. While Dye was incontrovertibly tied to Shaw, other evidence connects the Plough adventurers to London's antinomian controversies in less straightforward ways. Thomas Jupe, for instance, continued to live in St. Michael until his death in 1647. Predictably enough, he became an enthusiastic supporter of Parliament during the English Civil War, but if he earlier had been an admirer of Shaw, by the 1640s Jupe was perhaps tempering his earlier sectarian proclivities. Jupe's 1647 will was witnessed by Rowland Tompson, joiner of St. Stephen Coleman Street, who had been heavily involved in Shaw's High Commission case but not as a supporter.[39] Indeed, Tompson was a star witness against Shaw, attesting to several erroneous opinions for which the minister was prosecuted in 1629–30. Tompson was in fact a practiced heresy-hunter; earlier in the 1620s, he played a similar role in the trial of John Etherington, a London boxmaker who admitted that he flirted with Familism in his youth but claimed to have repudiated his errors. The prosecution of Etherington, which has been analyzed by Peter Lake, in many ways initiated the mushrooming controversies in London over Familism and antinomianism. Etherington's conviction as a Familistical heretic resulted from his

[38]The signature of the Husbandman John Robinson (*Husbandman 2*) strongly resembles (but is not conclusively identical to) the signature of John Robinson, 26, bachelor of St. Margaret New Fish Street, on his marriage bond, September 7, 1631, DL/A/D/002/MS10091/013, fol. 188r, LMA.

[39]Tompson's signature on the original will ("Thomas Jupe," PROB 10/684, TNA) matches his signature on the Shaw articles (SP 16/139/91, fol. 175r, TNA), leaving no doubt that the Coleman Street joiner signed both.

extensive private debates with godly laypeople, who then submitted their evidence to the authorities. Among these deponents was the joiner Rowland Tompson. Tompson manifestly reprised this role in Shaw's case. Another of the Husbandmen, Peter Worcester, also attended conferences with Etherington, supplying evidence against the unfortunate box maker.[40] Again, it is unlikely that these connections were wholly coincidental—they certainly place Jupe and Worcester squarely in the milieu of perfervid disputation that enveloped the London godly community in the late 1620s, and specifically tie Jupe to Peter Shaw's show trial. However, the evidence also hints that Worcester and Jupe (at least in his old age) were sympathetic to more mainstream forms of Puritan divinity, hardly supporting the notion that the Company of Husbandmen was a nest of secret Familists.[41]

The seemingly paradoxical presence of figures such as Dye, Peck, Jupe, Thomson, and Worcester should be taken as a sign of the fluidity and instability of religious debates and identities under discussion here. For while contemporaries routinely attempted to categorize and label one another, placing controverted opinions and people under rubrics such as Familist, antinomian, legalist, or even Puritan, the realities of the world of theological conversation in the godly community meant that these labels and categories were more fluid and permeable than many would admit. Disputations and prosecutions often began as private conferences between likeminded and theoretically kindred godly people, earnestly seeking truth together; only as these people felt each other out, articulating and clarifying their

[40]Peter Lake, *The Boxmaker's Revenge: 'Orthodoxy', 'Heterodoxy' and the Politics of the Parish in Early Stuart London* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2001); John Etherington, *The Defence of John Etherington Against Stephen Denison* (London, 1641), 3–4, 10–11, 30–32, 38, 45; Como and Lake, "Puritans, Antinomians and Laudians," 708–9.

[41]There are hints, however, that Worcester retained strong connections to radical Puritans. His daughter married Major Robert Cobbett, among the New Model Army's most extreme officers. Cobbett was involved in tolerationist petitioning campaigns and openly supported the Levellers. Cobbett was evidently close to his father-in-law, witnessing Worcester's will in 1656. PROB 11/257/612; PROB 11/298/136; "Peter Worcester," PROB 10/836, TNA. For Cobbett, see William Walwyn, *Walwyns Just Defence* (London, 1649), 2; J. Lilburne, *The Legall Fundamentall Liberties* (1649), 35–36.

respective positions, did such meetings turn sour, becoming (in effect) intelligence-gathering operations with the results reported to the authorities.[42] Moreover, the theological positions were unstable and subject to revision—Shaw, it was alleged, "hath bin observed to say and unsay; preach and unpreach, the same things"—and individuals clearly changed their minds and moved across different pietistic networks over time. Shaw, for all his supposed heterodoxy, was able to reconcile himself to the Laudian order, although his critics in the North continued to denounce his doctrinal "obsanities and paradoxes." Whatever his views, Shaw successfully melted into the Caroline church and even offered up an impudently anti-puritan petition to Laud in 1635.[43] Others ensnared in London's antinomian debates presumably followed equally winding spiritual paths. Nevertheless, the investigation undertaken here strongly suggests that the ideological and personal context for the Plough Patent is to be found in the environment of tense disputation and theological debate that troubled London's Puritan community between 1625 and 1631 and, most specifically, the show trial of Peter Shaw, which was grinding to conclusion in the very weeks the patent was granted.

Indeed, the timing of the patent, June 1630, raises the possibility that the project was launched in direct relation to Shaw's case. Given Dye's pivotal role in the undertaking, and in view of the centrality of the parishioners of St. Michael Crooked Lane, it is reasonable to hypothesize that the Plough project was hatched as a consequence of the unpleasant treatment meted out to the charismatic accused Familist preacher, and, more broadly, as a response to the deteriorating and embattled circumstances of those of similar pietistic inclination. The

[42]For this environment in pre-war England, see Peter Lake and David R. Como, "'Orthodoxy' and its Discontents: Dispute Settlement and the Production of 'Consensus' in the London (Puritan) 'Underground,'" *Journal of British Studies* 39 (2000): 34–70; for evolution during the civil wars, see Ann Hughes, "The Meanings of Religious Polemic," in *Puritanism: Transatlantic Perspectives on a Seventeenth-Century Anglo-American Faith,* ed. F. J. Bremer (Boston: MHS, 1993).

[43]Como and Lake, "Puritans, Antinomians and Laudians," 711; SP 16/263/40, fol. 87r, TNA; F. R. Raines and C. W. Sutton, "Life of Humphrey Chetham," *Chetham Society,* new series, 49 (1903): 50–51.

Sagadohoc grant perhaps was seen by its investors as a potential refuge, offering the prospect of an escape valve from an increasingly dangerous environment in which a combination of Laudian repression and mainstream Puritan hostility brought a series of prominent antinomian clergy and laypeople into legal jeopardy. When the *Plough* sailed in 1631, if Winthrop is to be believed, the ship evidently carried at least a handful of these exiled "famylistes."

Stephen Bachilor and the Hampshire Wing

The London nucleus of the company, centering on St. Michael Crooked Lane and the Binckes brothers, formed the heart of the Plough project, but it was not the only wing of the enterprise. The investors sought a pastor to lead their flock, and in doing so, they reached beyond the city. There may, perhaps, have been hopes that the embattled Shaw might be recruited. This is pure speculation; if overtures were made, they came to nothing. The privileged son of a Lancashire rector, Shaw regarded even the English provinces as beneath him. In 1631, although soundly rebuked in court, "Mr Shawe" had subsequently repaired to William Laud to obtain license to preach: "Noe place, said the Bishop [Laud], will serve him but he must needs be admitted to a church in London, and he came to me for admittance, which I purpose never, God willing, to graunt."[44] Shaw swallowed his pride and returned home to the North, but the anecdote suggests he was unlikely to be attracted to the deprivations of life in a newly planted colony at the edge of European habitation.

The Husbandmen recruited instead an older and steelier pastor, the nonconformist Stephen Bachilor, whose career has recently been illuminated by the research of Robert Charles Anderson. Almost seventy when the patent was granted, Bachilor had been removed from his living in the purge following James I's accession. In 1608, Bachilor was entangled in

[44]*High Commission,* 185. Shaw was still in London on December 21, 1631, when Hosea, son of Peter Shaw, "minister," was baptized at St. Giles Cripplegate. P69/GIS/A/002/MS06419/002, unfol., LMA.

an investigation of illegal Puritan books, and in 1614 he was again in court for circulating a slanderous libel. While there is no sign that he ever again held a post within the church, like many extreme Puritans, Bachilor exercised his gifts privately, teaching in the area of Newton Stacey, Hampshire, where he settled around 1614. This aged, Puritan militant was somehow lured into the Company of Husbandmen, staking a sizable sum of money and agreeing to emigrate as the colony's minister. He clearly carried into the project kinfolk and local associates. The most important of these associates was Richard Dummer, Bachilor's step-son-in-law, from a family based around South Stoneham, Hampshire.[45] Dummer was enticed into the company, and he and Bachilor soon doubled their investment while Bachilor also loaned the company a sum of money. Other colonists were likely recruited from Hampshire circles around Bachilor and Dummer. At least two passengers on the *Plough* were probably young sons of Thomas Talmage, a husbandman of Newton Stacey or its environs. The Talmages were unquestionably linked to the venture somehow.[46] Presumably, the Talmages were connected through Bachilor, who lived near them in Newton Stacey. Another of the Plough migrants, John Cerman—alias "Carman" or "Kirman"—was also possibly from this Hampshire network.[47]

[45]Robert Charles Anderson, *The Great Migration Begins,* 3 vols. (Boston: New England Historic Genealogical Society, 1995–96), 1:61–69, 588–95; see also his *Puritan Pedigrees: The Deep Roots of the Great Migration to New England* (Boston: New England Historic Genealogical Society, 2018), 306–25.

[46]The letter strongly implies that two or more Talmage sons had already arrived in Massachusetts, likely aboard the *Plough,* and that their father was linked to the venture, having consigned malt to the Plough Husbandmen. *Husbandmen 1* noted that "goodman Tamage and his wife tak it vere unkindly that you should kip his mallt and not let his sunnes haue a small quantetie of plattewer at his requst to be payd at return." "Goodman Tamage" was surely Thomas Talmage, whose three sons, William, Thomas, and Robert migrated early to New England (followed by Thomas Sr. himself). Thomas Sr. was brother of John Talmage, husbandmen of Newton Stacey, and the whole family was likely based there. See *Note-Book Kept by Thomas Lechford, Esq.,* ed. Edward Hale (Cambridge, MA: AAS, 1885), 294; Anderson, *Great Migration Begins,* 3:1798–99.

[47]*Husbandmen 1* spells his name "Cerman," *Husbandman 2* as "Carman." See Anderson, *Great Migration Begins,* 1:311–13; 2:1133–35, distinguishing this man from a Roxbury settler of the same name. He was possibly of the Carman clan of

There were thus two separate nodes of the Company of Husbandmen. The first centered on John Dye and his associates of St. Michael Crooked Lane with a pendant link to the three Binckes brothers. The second node, which perhaps coalesced as the London adventurers sought a suitable religious leader, centered on Bachilor and his Hampshire connections. What transactions led the Londoners to Bachilor is unclear, but he was plainly a nonconformist of the most uncompromising sort, and as such was a highly plausible target for early emigration to New England. As Anderson has shown, Bachilor had connections in Puritan circles across southern England, and he presumably came to the attention of the London patentees through such networks.[48] Whether he possessed unusual theological views that dovetailed with those of the Londoners is uncertain, but he was surely a figure from the outermost fringes of the Puritan community, where hardline nonconformity blurred into separatism—precisely the churning milieu inhabited by the squabbling radical Puritans discussed above. Whatever his ideological stance, Bachilor, together with Dummer, traveled to New England in the second wave of migration organized by the company in 1632. Here, Bachilor quickly clashed both with his clerical colleagues in Massachusetts and with other members of the Company of Husbandmen.

The Second Wave, Transatlantic Rumors, and Collapse

The project was quickly beset by controversy on both sides of the Atlantic. The failure to find an acceptable site within the bounds of the Lygonia patent created a quandary for the

---

Compton, Hampshire, which was tied to Richard Dummer's family. In 1642 Thomas Carman, gent. of Compton, together with Thomas Dummer (brother of Richard Dummer the Husbandman) jointly leased property in Durley, Hampshire. For the transaction, the ensuing legal disputes, and the Dummer family connections, cf. C 6/112/117; C 6/11/68; C 5/28/39, TNA; Joseph Lemuel Chester, "The Family of Dummer," *NEGHR* 35 (1881): 269.

[48]Anderson, *Deep Roots,* 310-15.

Plough migrants. Some of the passengers were from the outset allergic to the prospect of settling in Massachusetts, perhaps exhibiting an awareness that their opinions (and their projected enterprise) would not flourish under the gaze of the Bay's orthodox Puritans; the abortive flight towards the West Indies, undertaken just days after the *Plough* limped into Watertown, was the first sign of an almost desperate impulse to escape Massachusetts. When the *Plough*'s ramshackle condition forced the ship back to the Bay, debate erupted about what to do next, and disagreement immediately flared among the migrants. To resolve the controversy, the patentees appealed to the new General Court at Boston. On October 18, 1631, just two months after the ship landed, the court ordered some £12 to be paid to John Cerman "as his proper goods, & after the whole estate to be inventoryed, whereof the said John Kirman is to have an 8th parte." To execute the order, the court created a commission of five residents of Watertown—where the goods were evidently stored. The commission executed its task and Cerman received his money.[49] Cerman sought to withdraw his goods from the company stock that arrived in the *Plough*. Cracks were forming in the membership, hinting at disagreements about where to carry the project next. It is possible that amidst these disagreements, mutterings about the religious views of some of the Plough passengers were voiced.

Word of Cerman's abandonment of the project drifted back to England. The first surviving letter of the company members in London, written to the *Plough* passengers on March 8, 1632, alluded in dark terms not just to Cerman's defection but to other challenges at home. The Husbandmen praised Bachilor for his zealous commitment to the project, notwithstanding "all the oposition, all the suttel persawations of abundens of oposers that hath bin sturd up against us," hinting at serious obstacles

[49]*Records of the Governor and Company of the Massachusetts Bay,* ed. Nathaniel Shurtleff, 5 vols. (Boston: William White, 1853–54), 1:92 (hereafter cited as *Recs. of Mass. Bay*). In December 1632, the Londoners referred to a figure generated "accordinge to your praiseinge when you payde Carman." *Husbandman* 2.

in England, which had been amplified by "that untimly brech of our brother cerman."[50] Unfortunately, the patentees were not forthcoming about their "oposers," but the letter bears a plaintive air of grievance, suggesting that forces were aligning in England to thwart the enterprise.

The most serious resistance derived from Sir Ferdinando Gorges himself. The riot of grants issued by Gorges and his Council beginning in 1628 created a tangle of potentially competing, overlapping claims. In late 1631, Gorges issued a commission "to Richard Bradshaw of New England, of 1500 Acres of Land, to be allotted above the hedd of Pashippscot, on the north side thereof."[51] Here, the murky geographical boundaries of the Plough Patent proved perilous. When the London Husbandmen learned of Bradshaw's charter, they suspected that his patent included "a part as wee soposed of our former grant" and objected to Gorges. Both Gorges and Bradshaw responded assuring the Husbandmen that the grant "is not in our bouns"; however, Bradshaw soon prepared to sail from London to establish his claim. Worse still, dealings over Bradshaw's grant exposed more serious disagreements of the Husbandmen with Gorges. Bemoaning their labor and trouble in establishing the grant, the Husbandmen noted Gorges's rough language and complained that Sir Ferdinando was trying to limit the bounds of the original Plough Patent: "He douth afferm that he never gaue consent that you should haue aboufe forte mills in lenkth and 20 millses in bredth and sayeth that his one hand is not to your patten if it haue anne mor." Gorges likewise warned the Husbandmen that their claimed tract clashed with settlements already planted under the Council's authority. The London patentees scrambled to patch up the dispute, sending Gorges a sugar loaf as a gift, but "wee can proquer nothinge vnder his hand." Gorges instead ordered that a letter should be written to his agent Captain Walter Neale in New England to adjudicate the conflict, so that "bradshew and wee

[50] *Husbandmen 1.*

[51] "Recs. of the Council for New Eng," 50.

maight be bounded," giving "the Capten Comand to serch your patten what it is you haue vnder my lords hand and his."[52]

Despite the failure of the initial attempt to settle their "Sagadahoc" grant and notwithstanding Gorges's obstructionism, the London Husbandmen evidently anticipated that the Plough colonists, along with those sailing in 1632 with Bachilor, would try once again to settle Maine. The expectation was that they would go to Neale at Piscataqua to present their patent, after which they would make a second foray to occupy their assigned lands. It is likely, based on later statements, that the London patentees also approved a contingency plan: an order was given that a voyage should be undertaken to Virginia either to establish a plantation there or to dispose of the company's goods and recoup some of the investors' losses. Nevertheless, that was apparently seen as a fallback option and considerable efforts were thus made to recruit new planters and outfit two ships with goods to be sent for the settlement of Lygonia. The *Whale* eventually departed Southampton on April 8, 1632, with the *William and Francis* leaving London shortly thereafter. Among the passengers aboard these two ships were at least ten colonists for the project, including Bachilor, Dummer, and Thomas Jupe's son. The *Whale* arrived in Boston on May 26; the *William and Francis,* on June 5.[53]

Internal disputes among the settlers intensified. On the very day the second of the ships arrived, the General Court "ordered, that the goods of the company of husbandmen shalbe inventoryed by the beadle, and preserved here for the use and benefitt of the said company." Disagreement was

[52]*Husbandmen 1*; *Husbandmen 2*; these statements leave little doubt that the actual patent traveled with the settlers aboard the *Plough* explaining why the Londoners were unable to produce the original to appease Gorges.

[53]On the *Whale* were: Richard Dummer; Thomas Jupe's eldest son; Nathaniel Harresse, son of an unnamed company member; a boy, John Smith (son of Francis Smith, miller) sent upon the adventure of John Asten, mealman; Nathaniel Merriman (son of the London cooper George Merriman) sent upon Peter Worcester's adventure; Ann Smith, wife of John Smith the Husbandman, and her daughter. Aboard the *William and Francis* were Thomas Payn of Sandwich, a man "experensed in the makinge of sallt"; Stephen Bachilor; "John banester," "a vere pour Yorksher man," sponsored by Dummer and Bachilor. *Husbandmen 1*; *Winthrop's Journal*.

unfolding over the shared property of the Plough Company, making it necessary for the Bay authorities to intervene. Over the next weeks, signs emerged that the whole project was tottering. Leaders of the company, who had arrived the previous year on the *Plough,* had decided that settlement of the Sagadahoc lands was not feasible. Bryan Binckes and Peter Johnson, apparently in accord with an order from London, resolved to sail for Virginia. Others, led by the newly arrived Richard Dummer and Stephen Bachilor, disagreed and tried to stop Binckes and Johnson from departing. On July 3, the General Court placed Binckes and Johnson under a recognizance of £10 to ensure "that they shall not depart out of the pattent without leave from the Governor," and they were moreover enjoined "to attend upon the Court, when they shalbe called to give an account of their company goods."[54] The court's order signaled that grand plans for the settlement of Lygonia had collapsed, with disputes developing among the Husbandmen over how to proceed and what to do with the company's property.

Authorities in Massachusetts, for their part, were moving with impressive speed to mediate these conflicts. As in the previous October when they carefully inventoried and warehoused the cargo of the *Plough* to parcel out Cerman's share, the Bay Colony's magistrates deployed their fledgling politico-legal resources to manage and adjudicate the competing claims between the quarreling Husbandmen. Informally, the authorities were using techniques of godly arbitration and dispute-settlement common in early New England to contain the conflict, but at the same time they also formally mobilized their newly minted institutions and legal powers to ensure compliance.[55] The need to cope with the fallout of the project was rendered more urgent as it became clear that the migrants would not be removing to Sagadahoc.

[54]Shurtleff, ed., *Recs. of the Mass. Bay,* 1:96, 98, "John Smith was also placed under a £10 bond to account for 900d in his hands."

[55]For arbitration practices, often undergirded by Puritan religious aspirations, see David Thomas Konig, *Law and Society in Puritan Massachusetts: Essex County, 1629–1692* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1979), 107–13; David D. Hall, *A Reforming People: Puritanism and the Transformation of Public Life in New England* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2012), 137–40.

Indeed, on the same day that Johnson and Binckes were placed under restraint, the court issued a second order revealing that hopes of another foray to Maine had been abandoned. The General Court decreed that John Smith, an unaccompanied minor who had arrived on the *Whale* to settle the Plough lands, would be placed in service for five years under John Wilson, minister of Boston.[56] This tacitly acknowledged that neither Smith, nor the other Plough colonists, would be traveling to Maine and that some provision needed to be made for a boy stranded thousands of miles from home.

Amidst the collapse of the plan and disagreements among the Husbandmen in Massachusetts, rumors and charges began to fly. These rumors wafted back to England. In December 1632, the London Husbandmen wrote directly to Governor Winthrop complaining that "ther hath Come ouer from new England of Late divers reports of the harch dealeinge of Master Dummer against our Lovinge Breathren Bryan Binkes, Petter Johnsonn, and John Smith." Dummer, they heard, "hath not only taken from them that which was left them for there mainetenance by the Company, but alsoe retained that which wee sent, And doe keepe in there hands all that is there left of the Companies and retaine it." These initial reports were perhaps brought back by John Crispe, one of the *Plough* passengers, who returned to London in 1632. In response, in early November, company members posted "Letters" to New England, "Wherin wee dyd by all the power wee haue Command them to deliver our goods backe againe." Before the ship sailed carrying these letters, however, an epistle reached the London Husbandmen "from John Smith which doth for the most part Justifie that which wee haue heard, and alsoe another from Mr. Batchellor not denyinge the Same."[57] This, once again, hinted at the fault-lines that had developed in New England. Dummer and Bachilor appear to have tried to impede the voyage to Virginia of Binckes and Johnson, who were backed by John Smith and the Plough patentees in London. Dummer and Bachilor were,

[56]Shurtleff, ed., *Recs. of the Mass. Bay,* 1:98; *Husbandmen 1*.
[57]*Husbandmen 2*.

moreover, seeking to gain control of the company's property, presumably to recover their sizable investments in the venture. The two separate wings of the project—one centered in London on the core patentees, the other on Bachilor, Dummer, and their Hampshire friends—were at odds. As plans to colonize Lygonia foundered, the Company of Husbandmen began to disintegrate into its constituent parts.

Before Smith's letter arrived in London, however, the conflict in New England was apparently settled. Binckes and Johnson were released from their bond and permitted to leave. They presumably transferred a portion of the goods to Dummer, and he reportedly dropped his objections to their departure for the Chesapeake.[58] At some point after early August 1632, Binckes and Johnson sailed for Virginia carrying a significant share of the company's property. Smith's letter thus informed the London Husbandmen "that Bryan Binkes and Petter Johnsonn are gone to Vergenia accordinge to the Companies order." Nevertheless, the breach with Dummer and Bachilor, combined with mounting interest on loans to fund the project, meant that the Londoners were eager to recover all remaining company property and thus requested of the Massachusetts authorities "that whatsoeuer is there left of the Companies estat, should bee theire sould and returned into England, either by Billes of Exchange or in marchantable goodes," to Dye, Roch, Hardwin, or Jupe. The Londoners admitted that they owed Stephen Bachilor £60, and asked that he should receive that money out of the liquidated stock. But they hinted that Dummer had reneged on his promised obligation to the company and warned Winthrop that Dummer's share should be reduced accordingly.[59]

The degree of acrimony was extensive. As the London Husbandmen explained, Dummer and his allies had spread their own rumors that likewise flew back to England and accused Binckes and Johnson of malfeasance: "Heare hath binn a greate deale of Complainte, and much eivell sirmizinge of the

[58] *Winthrop's Journal*, 76–77.
[59] *Husbandmen* 2.

dealeinge of our Brethren departed to Vergenia." The London patentees defended Binckes and Johnson, insisting that their journey to Virginia was taken on "the Companies order." In a shot at Dummer and his allies, they predicted "that part of our estate Carried away to Vegenia, shalbee as well Improued for all the Company . . . As they will Improue ther owne in new England that doe soe surmize of there Brethren."[60] Recriminatory rumors were thus reverberating back and forth across the Atlantic bearing witness to the disintegration of the Plough project.

By early 1633, the enterprise was in ruins. Binckes and Johnson were possibly among the unfortunate passengers of the *Lyon,* which left Boston for Virginia in October 1632, only to sink, carrying her cargo and half her passengers to the bottom of the sea.[61] Whatever their fate, both men disappear from the records at this point. Although the London patentees requested the liquidation of the rest of the goods and called for the proceeds to be remitted to London, conflicts over company property persisted. In June 1633, Stephen Bachilor wrote to John Winthrop to claim four hogsheads of peas, which had arrived on the *William and Francis* and had been in storage for a year in Newtowne. The peas, Bachilor asserted, had wrongly been assigned to John Wilson when Wilson had contracted the boy John Smith as his servant. Bachilor claimed the peas belonged not to the child but to the company, and the cleric thus claimed them as part of the debt owed him. Bachilor indignantly refuted rumors that he had appropriated young John Smith's share of the freight: "it is conceaued that the goods of the boye came wholly or in parte to me, which if it may but probably appeare I will make 7 fould Satisfaction."[62] The unseemly spat between two Puritan ministers over barrels of peas is a sign that wrangling over company goods was by no means resolved. Indeed, the Bay authorities were still trying to untangle competing counterclaims two years later, when the

[60] *Husbandmen* 2.
[61] *Winthrop's Journal,* 81–89.
[62] *Winthrop Papers,* 3:122–24.

General Court ordered "to John Kirman, out of the estate of the Company of husbandmen the somme of Foure and twenty pounds, eleven shillings and fyve pence being the remainder of the eight parte of the said estate, which was by order of Court gyven the said John Kirman."[63] This suggests that the government still held in trust over £200 of company property in April 1635, almost four years after the *Plough* landed.

The contests over the company's goods left a lasting imprint on the disputants. A decade later, Bachilor ascribed the failure of the original Plough settlement to precisely these battles, remarking that the design to establish him as the colony's pastor had imploded "vpon that disaster which happened to the goods of the Company by the false dealing of thos entrusted by Vs with the ploughe ship, and our goods therin," strongly implying that he believed Binckes, Johnson, Smith, and Crispe had defrauded the company and destroyed the enterprise.[64]

We are now better placed to assess Winthrop's claims about the "famylistes" of the *Plough*. Several *Plough* passengers—Binckes, Smith, Crispe, Johnson, and possibly some of the ship's unidentified passengers—were part of the project's London node, centered around John Dye and St. Michael Crooked Lane (indeed, Crispe and Smith were likely Crooked Lane householders). It is probable that one or more of these people, like John Dye, had been caught up in the charismatic ministry of Peter Shaw. These London-based adventurers, wintering in Massachusetts, had ample opportunity to consort with other recent transplants, during which they may have indicated their religious preferences. Moreover, the London Husbandmen soon clashed with those from the project's other wing—the Hampshire connection surrounding Dummer and Bachilor. While it is unclear if there were religious undercurrents to this infighting, the resulting atmosphere of rumor and recrimination was well suited to incubate accusations of deviance, even heterodoxy. At some stage, the Londoners provoked suspicion that they subscribed to pietistic forms which were, during

[63]Shurtleff, ed., *Recs. of the Mass. Bay,* 1:143.
[64]*Winthrop Papers,* 4:447.

these months, still roiling London's godly community. Soon the London wing of the fellowship melted away, with Binckes and Johnson heading to Virginia, Crispe to England, and Smith disappearing from surviving records (by contrast, the *Plough* passengers tied to the project's Hampshire wing, Cerman and the Talmages, settled in Massachusetts). In all likelihood, it was the fleeing Londoners who provoked Winthrop's assessment that "most of them proved famylistes, & vanished away."

The Plough Project and New England's Theological Controversies

This raises the question of whether the ill-fated fellowship of the *Plough* played any deeper role in the furor that erupted when, in 1636, John Wheelwright, Anne Hutchinson, and their backers provoked controversies over "free grace," reviving anew allegations of Familism and antinomianism. Winthrop's comment implied that all the *Plough*'s passengers "vanished away," but this was not so. Those of the Hampshire coterie settled permanently in the Bay Colony coalescing around Stephen Bachilor as their leader. But perhaps concerned about the doctrinal rectitude or querulous comportment of the bickering Husbandmen, the Bay authorities initially treated Bachilor with suspicion. In October 1632, the General Court ordered that "Mr. Batchelor is required to forbeare exerciseing his guifts as a pastor or teacher publiquely, in our pattent, unlesse it be to those hee brought with him, for his contempt of authority & till some scandles be removed."[65] Exactly what Bachilor did to merit this suspicion is unclear. He was undoubtedly a man of strong will and acerbic disposition, capable of infuriating even natural allies. However, it is also possible that there was concern about his teachings, particularly if, as Winthrop suggests, other Husbandmen had come under suspicion for heterodoxy. Despite Bachilor's clash over company property, it is not impossible that he shared pietistic tendencies with more exuberant members. Even if he was not a closet Familist, Bachilor

[65]Shurtleff, ed., *Recs. of the Mass. Bay,* 1:100.

may have been among those English Puritans who believed that godly practical divinity had become too focused on sanctification and duties, perhaps explaining why the Plough patentees regarded him as an acceptable choice for their minister in 1631.

Through some transactions that are as mysterious as the reasons underlying his initial proscription, Bachilor was able to overcome the Bay authorities' doubts. In March 1633, the order "which restrained him from further gathering a church" was lifted.[66] Bachilor became pastor of the Saugus congregation and was joined by several Hampshiremen who were part of the Plough project. Richard Dummer acquired property in Saugus, John Cermen moved there, and several of the Talmages lived in the town.[67] Part of the fellowship of Husbandmen survived for a time folded into the community at Saugus. As was his wont, Bachilor immediately quarreled with his neighbors, and the congregation became bitterly divided. By 1636, Bachilor had been forced from his ministry and had moved to Newbury along with his kinsman Dummer. After relocating to Hampton, where Bachilor acquired another pastorate, he was again in trouble, this time for tempting the chastity of a congregant's wife; in 1644, he relocated for a fourth time to Portsmouth; again trailed by rumors of sexual and marital impropriety, he finally left New England and returned to London, dying in 1656.[68] In all of this, there were no charges that Bachilor's doctrine was erroneous. At no point during the antinomian ructions was he accused of supporting Wheelwright, Hutchinson, or their followers. However, his departure from Saugus's pulpit in 1636 meant that he was far less exposed to scrutiny than others, and in 1644, when he contemplated removal to Wells in Maine, Bachilor certainly did express sympathy with the still-suspect leader of the "free grace" party, declaring that "mr. Wheelwright stablished in those partes is

[66]Shurtleff, ed., *Recs. of the Mass. Bay,* 1:103.

[67]Thomas Talmage Sr. emigrated to New England and resided at Lynn (Saugus) by 1634 while two of his sons, William and Thomas Jr., also lived in Lynn in the 1630s. Anderson, *Great Migration Begins,* 1:589; 2:1133; 3:1798–99; Arthur White Talmadge, *The Talmadge, Tallmadge and Talmage Genealogy* (New York: Grafton Press, 1909), 23.

[68]Anderson, *Great Migration Begins,* 1:66–67; Anderson, *Deep Roots,* 324.

not a weak motive to . . . drawe me" to Maine, perhaps shining light on Bachilor's ideological preferences.[69] While Bachilor's troubles evidently flowed more from his combative personality than his teachings, the possibility cannot be dismissed that his earlier attachment to the Plough project bespoke some species of theological peculiarity or broadmindedness, manifesting itself in his ongoing regard for Wheelwright.

This is perhaps the more likely given that Bachilor's kinsman, Dummer, experienced serious difficulties during the convulsive disputes over "free grace." Dummer and his wife Jane were regarded as supporters of so-called antinomians and Familists. In November 1637, Dummer was one of three Newbury men disarmed along with others who had subscribed to a "seditious" petition in support of Wheelwright.[70] According to the minister John Eliot, the real driving force behind the family's theological position was Jane Dummer. As Eliot recalled, "she was a Godly woman, but by the seduction of some of her acquaintances she led away into the new opinions in Mris Hutchinsons time, & her husband removing to Nubery she there openly declared herselfe, & did also (together with other indeavour) seduce her husband." On Eliot's account, her unsavory associations cost her dearly: "she being . . . with child & ill; Mr Clark (one of the same opinions) unskillfully gave her a vomit, which did in such manner . . . torment her . . . that she dyed in a most uncomfortable manner."[71] This was presumably Dr. John Clarke, a recent arrival and known sympathizer with Wheelwright and Hutchinson.

The Dummers' theological position is the most suggestive evidence that the earlier religious disposition of the Plough patentees might have played a role in the controversies of 1636–38. Were the Dummers predisposed to novel ideas as a

[69]*Winthrop Papers,* 4:449.

[70]Shurtleff, ed., *Recs. of the Mass. Bay,* 1:212; Michael P. Winship, *Making Heretics: Militant Protestantism and Free Grace in Massachusetts* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2002), 96, 98, 121, 135, 295n8.

[71]Anderson, *Great Migration Begins,* 1:589; *A Report of the Record Commissioners, Containing the Roxbury Land and Church Records,* 2nd ed. (Boston: Rockwell and Churchill, 1884), 77; Anderson, *Deep Roots,* 319–24, corrects Eliot's misidentification of her as Mary Dummer.

result of earlier exposure to the Familistical conceits current among the Husbandmen? It should be emphasized that Eliot specified that the two were "seduced" into "new opinions," implying there were no previous hints of heterodoxy in the family. Many Massachusetts residents had been newly energized by Hutchinson, Wheelwright, and their friends, and by 1637 there were plenty of people like Clarke capable of leading the Dummers towards novel pietistic conclusions. But it is also possible that this atmosphere of experimentation and escalating theological radicalism may merely have amplified an existing pietistic disposition, driving the Dummers into a posture of outward confrontation that eventually registered on the radar of Eliot, who was emerging as a hardline opponent of the innovations sweeping the colony.

Regardless of the precise trajectory of his theological development, by late 1637 Richard Dummer's status was crumbling in Massachusetts, and he sailed for England. At this point, Dummer reconnected with the London Husbandmen, sparking a renewed campaign to revive the dormant Plough Patent in Maine. He was clearly contemplating abandonment of the Bay Colony, probably with the "Sagadahoc" lands as one alternative for resettlement; however, this was not his only option. In the summer of 1638, Dummer returned to New England, conveying with him two of his adult brothers and their families. In August 1638, Dummer and several of his "friends" were admitted as freeman of Aquidneck, the Narragansett Bay settlement recently founded by exiles from Boston (including Anne Hutchinson and Dr. John Clarke). Dummer, his brothers, and his "friends" received land grants, and Dummer agreed to build a mill there. Alongside renewed efforts to resuscitate the Plough Patent, Dummer and his allies were clearly preparing for relocation to Aquidneck.[72] He seems to have been trying to keep his options open, maintaining channels to Massachusetts even as he explored multiple possibilities for relocation. In the end, Dummer opted to stay in Massachusetts. In 1639,

[72] *Records of the Colony of Rhode Island and Providence Plantations,* 10 vols. (Providence: A. C. Greene, 1856–65), 1:58–60.

he loaned money to the colony, perhaps designed to ease a rapprochement.[73] In 1641, he formally "gave satisfaction" to the General Court, finalizing his rehabilitation. However, even then, Dummer apparently submitted in a questionable manner—he was ordered to confer with the ministers Eliot and Wilson "for his judgment," implying that doubts persisted about Dummer's orthodoxy.[74] And as we will see, in the same year, Dummer, with his kinsman Bachilor, persisted in pursuing the Plough Patent in Maine, suggesting he was still wavering about his future in Massachusetts. There thus remain questions about Dummer's own ideological commitments despite his outward reconciliation with the Bay authorities.

Notwithstanding these intriguing hints about Bachilor and the Dummers, there are few conclusive signs that the Company of Husbandmen exerted a deep or lasting religious influence on Massachusetts. As Michael Winship has shown, despite free-flowing accusations of antinomianism and Familism in 1636–38, the evidence strongly suggests that most of the initial theological deviations of Boston's so-called antinomians emerged from the heart of godly divinity, involving modest escalations upon the reformed doctrine being taught, if idiosyncratically, by ministers such as Cotton and Wheelwright.[75] However, the vehement response greeting these opinions was shaped from the beginning by the very real existence back in England of preachers such as Shaw who disrupted London's godly community in the late 1620s. The arrival of the Plough patentees in 1631 appears to have brought the surging electricity of these conflicts to the Bay Colony, alerting those in Boston almost as soon as the new settlement had taken root. Something the *Plough* passengers did or said triggered suspicions in Winthrop and others, reminding the saints of the Bay of the unpleasant disputes that were still troubling London's Puritan community. The strong, if indirect, evidence

[73]Anderson, *Great Migration Begins,* 1:589.

[74]Shurtleff, ed., *Recs. of the Mass. Bay,* 1:339.

[75]Winship, *Making Heretics,* 28–63; Bozeman, *Precisianist Strain,* is more inclined to suggest that Cotton's "semi-antinomian" divinity strayed into unorthodox territory.

linking the company to Shaw's tumultuous ministry suggests that Winthrop's suspicions were not mere fantasy and that some who alighted from the *Plough* were religious radicals, of antinomian sympathy. While it is not impossible that one or two of these passengers might have escaped Winthrop's ken and quietly settled into life in Massachusetts only to cause trouble again in 1636, the evidence presented here concerning the identities and subsequent dispersal of the Husbandmen renders it unlikely that these people embedded themselves in New England, forming a secretive league of antinomians and Familists.[76] But their appearance in 1631, and the jolt of concern they evidently created, suggests that their significance lies chiefly in the way the project put the Bay magistrates and ministers on guard, vividly reminding them of the bitter theological battles unfolding in England. The godly patriarchs of the new colony were surely aware of these conflicts, at least by report, and they were no doubt at pains to keep them from migrating to their new Puritan stronghold. The arrival of the *Plough* functioned as a warning, one that perhaps intensified the vigilance of Winthrop and others, and made it more likely that in 1636, they would interpret the activities of Hutchinson, Wheelwright, and their allies according to scripted categories of heresy and error that had taken shape in the previous decade.[77]

Later Reverberations of the Plough Project

New England's controversies over Familism and antinomianism did, however, exert an oblique influence over the Plough

[76]Winship's account, while stressing the relative orthodoxy of Cotton's and Wheelwright's teachings, presumes the existence, somewhere in Massachusetts, of unidentified extremists, who helped push Hutchinson's clique towards more radical positions. The involvement of one or more of the Husbandmen in this shadowy process must remain a tantalizing, but unproven, possibility. Intriguingly, other colonists were likely exposed to Shaw's London ministry, including the obstreperous Hutchinsonian, William Dyer, and Martha Collins of Newtowne (who rendered Shaw's message in a decidedly orthodox fashion, hinting again at the instability and ambiguity of the theological positions discussed here). Winship, *Making Heretics,* 52, 67–68.

[77]Winship sees the polarizing intervention coming not from Winthrop but from ministers who arrived later, particularly Thomas Shepard. *Making Heretics,* 67–68. See also Como, *Blown by the Spirit,* 441–44.

project, ushering in the final phase of the enterprise. Dummer's return to England in 1638 evidently led him to resume contact with the London Husbandmen. Despite the dissolution of Gorges's Council of New England in 1635, the existence of the Plough Patent held out promise for future colonization, and the Husbandmen remained hopeful that they could recoup their investment. Dummer and the London Husbandmen thus reportedly laid aside old differences to revive their dormant claim. According to William Hubbard's later account, "*John Dye* . . . and his *Partners* took in another as Partner and Associate with them, *Mr. Richard Dummer* of *Newbury* in *New-England,* in the *year 1638,* to whom they delivered the Original Patent, with an order from them and in their Name, to take up the Land described in the *Patent*." In 1683, Dummer's son Jeremiah petitioned the Massachusetts General Court, claiming that Richard Dummer "was *wholly* entrusted with the Plough Patent, and the management of sundry concerns relating to the same, by virtue of a power derived from the patentees." Jeremiah's petition suggested that Richard "disbursed sundry sums of money" in pursuit of his charge, supporting Hubbard's claim that fresh efforts were made to jumpstart a colony in Maine. A letter from Thomas Gorges, deputy governor of Maine, confirms this picture, asserting that in 1641, Dummer and Bachilor, working in concert, possessed a "coppy of the plough patent land of Sagedehadocke" and were actively using it to "lay clayme to that land." These efforts failed. In Hubbard's telling, Richard Dummer was "denied opportunity to effect" a new settlement; according to his son, "the said patent being ordered home for England," the surviving London patentees "granted unto" Richard Dummer "800 and odd acres of lands, which was laid out at Casco Bay" in Maine.[78] This was the last hint of any attempt by the original

[78]Hubbard, *Narrative,* appendix, 9-10; George Folsom, *History of Saco and Biddeford, with Notices of other Early Settlements, and the Proprietary Governments, in Maine* (Saco, ME: Alex Putnam, 1830), unpag. addition. Hubbard's account disagrees with Jeremiah's in suggesting that Richard Dummer handed the patent to Rigby's agent Cleeve in New England rather than sending it back to London. *The Letters of Thomas Gorges: Deputy Governor of the Province of Maine, 1640–1643,* ed. Robert E. Moody

Company of Husbandmen to colonize Maine. The turbulence created by New England's "free grace" controversy, combined with the patentees' lingering hopes to exploit their grant, helped to generate a spasm of renewed activity, initiating the ultimate episode of this radical Puritan colonization scheme.

In 1643, the remaining London patentees made a final bid to redeem their investment, when "John Dy Thomas Jupe and others their Associats being the survivours of Bryan Bincks" found a buyer for their charter. On April 7, they conveyed their title to Alexander Rigby, a Lancashire gentleman and militant war-party MP.[79] The sale of the Plough Patent to Rigby marked the end of the Company of the Husbandmen. How many of the original patentees were present to profit from the deal is unclear. John Winthrop later scoffed that the assignment conveying the patent to Rigby bore the names of only two original patentees.[80] Whether true or not, at least seven London Husbandmen survived to 1643. Their later lives followed predictable, if interesting paths: all supported Parliament when the English Civil War erupted in 1642, and several held positions of prominence within the new Roundhead military-bureaucratic establishment (with one becoming an MP in the 1650s).[81] A handful in fact survived the Restoration—occasionally revealing ongoing ties of business or friendship—until the last of the

(Portland: Maine Historical Society, 1978), 32, states explicitly that Bachilor had a "coppy" of the patent, leaving much uncertainty about the movements of the original.

[79]The sale was probably brokered by George Cleeve, a disaffected Maine official, who returned to London in 1642 "to get a patent" for his claims against Gorges; Cleeve then acted as Rigby's New England agent in enforcing the Plough Patent. CO 1/33/109, fol. 287r, TNA; *Thomas Gorges,* 113; *Farnham Papers,* 133–36; *Winthrop Papers,* 4:429–31; Farber, "Lygonia," 499–503.

[80]*Winthrop's Journal,* 619.

[81]Jupe was a London Common Councillor and war contractor: *A Letter from Mercurius Civicus to Mercurius Rusticus* (1643), 15; Philipp J. C. Elliot-Wright, *English Civil War* (London: Brassey's, 1997), 90; SP 28/129, part 4, fols. 4, 6r; SP 28/170, part 1, unfol., TNA; Roger Binckes became paymaster and governor of Parliament's Ely House hospital for maimed soldiers: PROB 11/215/331; SP 28/141A, fols. 1004r, 1015r; SP 28/141B, fols. 816r, 817v, 843r, TNA; Nathaniel Whetham became first a major, then a garrison commander and MP under the protectorate: Whetham, *Nathaniel Whetham,* 44–227.

known patentees, Grace Hardwin, died in 1670.[82] After the sale to Rigby in 1643, however, all claims by the original Company of Husbandmen were apparently extinguished.

Rigby was a consummate parliamentarian insider and, unlike the politically marginal London artificers who originally obtained the charter, the MP was able to devote significant personal and political clout to the project. As Hannah Farber's recent work reveals, Rigby dispatched his agents, George Cleeve and Thomas Morton, to make good his authority over Lygonia. This collided with the claims of Gorges, his heirs, and their colonial surrogates, provoking significant tension in London and among the scattered settlers in Maine. Rigby was able to use his sway in Parliament to secure confirmation of his patent according to its most generous geographical interpretation and thereby managed for a time to assert authority through his agents over the territory. Only after Rigby died in 1650 did the Lygonia province fade away, effectively eclipsing the claim derived from the Plough Patent. In 1651, the Massachusetts Bay Colony flexed its muscles and began to incorporate Maine into its domain, a process it extended and consolidated through the rest of the decade, finally consuming the Lygonia territories in 1658.[83] Although Rigby's heirs waged a fitful campaign to recover a stake in the lands, the power grab by the Bay Colony definitively put paid to the Plough enterprise that began in 1630.[84]

The Company of Husbandmen and the Early History of New England

The story of the Plough Patent nevertheless has a number of important implications for the history of New England. The

[82]Jupe was business partner to John Roch's brother Thomas. Elliot-Wright, *English Civil War*, 90. John Roch's widow, Ellen, named Grace Hardwin overseer of her will in 1664. Court of Arches Wills: VH95/1671, VH95/1672, Lambeth Palace Library, London, UK.

[83]Farber, "Lygonia," 501–13; Williamson, *Maine*, 1:334–57.

[84]See *To the Right Honourable The Parliament of the Common-wealth of England, And the Dominions thereto belonging* [1659]; CO 1/33/109, TNA; *Farnham Papers*, 133–36.

enterprise, failure though it was, transports us to a moment early in the English colonization of the Atlantic when settlement patterns and institutional developments that would ultimately appear inexorable were still uncertain and left wide latitude for competing projects and visions, a field of possibilities encouraged by the scattershot approach of Gorges and his Council of New England. For a start, the Plough Patent suggests that the goal of creating a kind of radical Puritan countercolony to provide a haven for sectarian or dissident saints may have emerged very soon on the heels of the foundation of the Massachusetts Bay Colony. Of course, the Plough patentees left no manifestos regarding their intentions, but much circumstantial evidence suggests that at least some Husbandmen were enmeshed in heterodox Puritan circles, explaining Winthrop's laconic verdict on the "famylistes" of the *Plough*. After it was decided that the Maine lands were unsuitable, these migrants revealed firm determination to escape the dominance of Boston—first seeking to sail for the Caribbean, then carrying their project to Virginia—suggesting they were averse to settlement in Massachusetts Bay, which they perhaps viewed not as a city on a hill but as a potential Puritan prison. Their aim was evidently to create a new, autonomous plantation, whether in Maine, the Antilles, or Virginia.

That disaffected saints, estranged from mainstream Puritan divinity, might have aspired to create a refuge in the Americas is hardly surprising. Plymouth was, after all, a variation on this theme, engineered by sectarian Puritans of separatist inclination. And, of course, in 1636, the expulsion of Roger Williams from Massachusetts set in motion the creation of a cluster of precisely such sectarian refuges along Narragansett Bay. In many ways, Providence and its sister colonies came to fulfill exactly the sort of role that, on the account presented here, was envisioned by some of the Husbandmen.[85]

Equally interesting, from the broader perspective of the history of New England, is what the story of the Plough Patent

[85]Gura, *Glimpse of Sion's Glory*; John Donoghue, *Fire under the Ashes: An Atlantic History of the English Revolution* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2013).

reveals about the nature of the Massachusetts Bay Colony in its earliest days. On its face, the Plough enterprise was similar to the Massachusetts project in scope and ambition. Regardless of whether its architects saw "Sagadahoc" as a haven for unorthodox saints, the plan itself had many striking parallels with the fledgling Massachusetts undertaking. The expansive land grant extracted from Gorges together with the alleged power conferred "to make laws" meant that like the Massachusetts Bay Company, the Husbandmen theoretically had license to create a large, autonomous colony, which could be shaped and governed according to their own designs. As in the Massachusetts Bay Company, there was no divide between a ruling cadre of patentees in England, on the one hand, and the settlers sent to America, on the other—members of the company, including the patentees and their children, traveled to the settlement, and new members were welcomed into the joint-stock as they contributed money and manpower. Just as the Massachusetts colonists conveyed their charter to New England, so too the Sagadahoc Patent appears to have traveled aboard the *Plough* with the first wave of settlers. In many respects, the Company of Husbandmen looks highly analogous to the Bay Company, perhaps by intention and imitation.

It is also clear, however, that the Husbandmen were completely outmatched in terms of resources, political clout, and administrative capabilities. The humble, plebeian quality of the patentees meant not only that they were forced to borrow heavily to keep their enterprise afloat, but also that they lacked the political connections and know-how that allowed the Bay Company to take off with such spectacular effect in 1629. Where the Bay Company adroitly solidified its grant by procuring an independent charter from the crown, the Husbandmen were able to "proquer nothinge" from Gorges, despite the emoluments and efforts they devoted to courting him.

Perhaps even more impressive was the level of organization, cohesion, and administrative acumen that the Bay Colony was able to muster, even in the first months of its existence, characteristics plainly apparent in its response to the Husbandmen. Within weeks of the *Plough*'s landing, the General Court was

busily intervening in the affairs of the new arrivals, taking into trust the company's assets, and mediating burgeoning disputes between the Husbandmen with a scrupulously even hand. Commissioners were empaneled, property inventoried, goods painstakingly stored, recognizances taken, and the movements of the settlers monitored. Considerable efforts were made to dampen, defuse, and if necessary, adjudicate the conflicts, reflecting deep impulses of the New England godly towards neighborly arbitration, but also exacting concern for the property claims of the sparring migrants, as well as willingness to deploy the nascent legal mechanisms of the Bay Colony to head off the dispute. The conscientious regard for the affairs of the Husbandmen was remarkable, ensuring that years after the *Plough*'s arrival, the Massachusetts authorities continued to warehouse and preserve in trust the remaining goods of the consortium. This stewardship and legal punctiliousness bespoke an extraordinary level of ad hoc governing and bureaucratic capacity, which had been quickly and effectively transplanted and adapted from England despite the very challenging conditions that attended the creation of a new colony from scratch. These were, after all, people who had been living in tents and wigwams a year earlier. The swift collapse of the Company of Husbandmen, mired in internal sniping, indebtedness, and general dysfunction, is a reminder that this level of cohesion and smooth, seamless governance was not a natural, easy, or straightforward condition that could be replicated without problems by all who arrived with English customs and capital in hand. While early Massachusetts was obviously not without its own internal disputes—which called into being similar attempts at communal mediation and, in some cases, legal policing—the reaction to the Husbandmen is a tribute to the strikingly effective operation of the Bay Colony's infant institutions, almost from the plantation's inception.[86]

Of course, the apparently evenhanded and meticulous regard the Bay authorities revealed in dealing with the Husbandmen

[86]See further Michael P. Winship, *Godly Republicanism: Puritans, Pilgrims, and a City on a Hill* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2012).

was not an unconditional sign of benevolence or godly charity. The moment the Bay authorities claimed oversight of the company's estate, presuming to hold, inventory, and dole out the Husbandmen's goods, the magistrates were in effect asserting power and authority over a potentially rival colonial scheme. The scrupulous regard for the Husbandmen's property contained within it a jurisdictional assertion that should not be ignored. In this view, the fastidious attention of the General Court looks rather less like impartial devotion to the rule of law or sanctity of private property and more like a bid to contain, control, and perhaps absorb a colonization project that, on paper and in aspiration, appeared just as ambitious and formidable as the Massachusetts Bay Colony. Even discounting the presence of the *Plough*'s "famylistes," Winthrop and his fellow magistrates were unlikely to view the pretensions of the Husbandmen in a positive light. It is no surprise that Lygonia, like the rest of the scattered settlements of Maine, soon fell prey to the more unabashed expansionism of the Massachusetts Bay Colony, which, partly through intimidation and partly by holding out the lure of its own stable, authoritative, and efficacious governing institutions, swallowed its northern neighbors whole in the 1650s.

David R. Como *is professor of history at Stanford University. He is author of* Blown by the Spirit: Puritanism and the Emergence of an Antinomian Underground in Pre–Civil-War England *(Stanford, 2004) and* Radical Parliamentarians and the English Civil War *(Oxford University Press, 2018), co-winner of the 2019 Pacific Coast Conference on British Studies Book Prize.*